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History of Keralam Upto the 12th Century

Module II

Keralam upto Iron Age

Chapter: 3

The Megalithic Culture

Megaliths: Typology

Megaliths are large stone monuments constructed during the Iron Age and Early Historic period, roughly between 1000 BCE and 500 CE. The term “megalith” comes from the Greek words mega, meaning big, and lithos, meaning stone. These monuments were mainly built to commemorate the dead, and they reflect the burial practices and belief systems of early societies. In Kerala, megaliths form the most important archaeological evidence for understanding ancient history, especially because written records from this period are very limited. The study of these monuments began in India with J. Babington in 1819. Megaliths are not uniform; they appear in different forms based on materials, structure, and function. This variation is known as their typology.

In Kerala, we find several types such as Kodakkal (umbrella stone), Thoppikkal (capstone), rock-cut chambers, cist burials, dolmens, menhirs, stone circles, urns, and sarcophagi. Each of these types gives us valuable information about the burial customs, social life, and technological development of the megalithic people. As mentioned earlier, Megaliths are large stone monuments that form one of the most important sources for understanding the ancient history of Kerala. These structures were built during the Iron Age and Early Historic period, generally dated between 1000 BCE and 500 CE. The term “megalith” is derived from two Greek words: mega, meaning “big,” and lithos, meaning “stone.” Together, the word literally translates to “big stone.” The term was first coined by Algernon Herbert, and it has since been widely used in archaeology to describe such monumental stone constructions found across different parts of the world.

Megaliths are primarily associated with burial practices. They were constructed to honour and commemorate the dead, reflecting the beliefs and rituals of early societies regarding death and the afterlife. These monuments often served as burial markers or grave structures, under which the remains of the deceased were placed. Along with the human remains, various grave goods such as pottery, iron tools, ornaments, and beads were also deposited. Megaliths are not just burial monuments; they are also valuable cultural and historical records. They provide crucial insights into the social, economic, and technological life of early communities in Kerala. For instance, the presence of iron tools suggests the use of advanced metal technology, while the variety of pottery styles reflects artistic development and trade connections. The construction of these large stone structures itself indicates a certain level of social organization and collective effort.

Thus, megaliths serve as the foremost archaeological evidence for reconstructing the early history of Kerala. Since written records from this period are scarce, these monuments act as primary sources for historians and archaeologists. By studying them, scholars can better understand the burial customs, belief systems, material culture, and overall way of life of the people who lived in Kerala during the Iron Age and Early Historic period

The systematic study of megaliths in India began in 1819 with the work of J. Babington, who conducted one of the earliest excavations of burial sites in the Kozhikode region of present-day Kerala. Although he did not use the term “megalith,” his work laid the foundation for later archaeological research in this field. He referred to these burial monuments by their local name, Pandoo Kuzhi (also called Pandoo Coolies), which means ancient burial pits. This local terminology reflects the long-standing awareness among the people of Kerala about these structures, even before formal archaeological studies began. Megaliths are closely associated with burial practices, as they primarily served as monuments to commemorate the dead. Archaeological evidence from South India reveals two main types of burial practices during the megalithic period: primary burial and secondary burial. In the primary burial system, the complete skeleton of the deceased was interred in the grave. The body was usually placed in an extended position and buried

along with personal belongings. Such burials provide direct evidence of the physical remains of individuals. A well-known example of primary burial is found at Adichanallur in Tamil Nadu. However, this type of burial has not been commonly identified in Kerala.

In contrast, the secondary burial system is more typical of Kerala. In this method, the body was either cremated or left exposed to natural decomposition. After this process, the remaining bone fragments were carefully collected and placed inside burial containers such as urns or stone structures. These fractional burials indicate a complex funerary ritual and suggest beliefs related to purification or transformation after death. An important feature of megalithic burials is the presence of grave goods. These include various objects placed along with the dead, such as pottery (especially Black and Red Ware), iron tools and weapons, beads made of semi-precious stones, and sometimes bronze objects. The inclusion of such items suggests that the megalithic people believed in an afterlife where these objects would be useful. At the same time, these materials provide valuable insights into the technological advancement, craftsmanship, trade connections, and social life of the early inhabitants of Kerala. Thus, the study of burial practices and associated materials plays a crucial role in reconstructing the cultural and historical background of the megalithic society.

Typology of Megaliths

The megaliths of Kerala can be broadly classified based on the materials used in their construction and their structural features. The three major materials employed are laterite stone, granite, and terracotta, each giving rise to distinct types of megalithic monuments. This typological classification helps archaeologists understand regional variations, technological skills, and cultural practices of the megalithic society. The laterite megaliths are among the most distinctive and region-specific forms found in Kerala, particularly concentrated in the northern districts. These include structures such as Kodakkal (umbrella stone), Thoppikkal (capstone), rock-cut chambers, and stone circles. Laterite, being a locally available and easily workable material, was extensively used in this region. Kodakkal, for instance, is unique to Kerala and reflects a high degree of craftsmanship in shaping and assembling large stone blocks. Similarly, Thoppikkal consists of a large capstone supported by smaller stones, while rock-cut chambers involve chambers carved into laterite rock surfaces.

The granite megaliths are more widely distributed across Kerala and are not confined to a particular region. These include cists, dolmens, menhirs, and stone circles. Granite, being a harder and more durable material, required more advanced techniques for quarrying and construction. Cists are box-like burial chambers made of stone slabs, often covered with a capstone. Dolmens are table-like structures formed by placing a large horizontal slab over vertical stones. Menhirs are tall, upright standing stones, possibly serving as memorial markers. Stone circles, formed by arranging stones in a circular pattern, often demarcate burial sites.

The third category consists of terracotta megaliths, which include urns and sarcophagi. Unlike stone structures, these are large clay containers used for burial purposes, particularly for secondary burials. Although they lack a lithic (stone) component, their large size and funerary function justify their inclusion under megaliths. These urns often contained bone fragments along with grave goods. Overall, the distribution of these megalithic types shows a marked concentration in the northern parts of Kerala, including districts such as Thrissur, Palakkad, Malappuram, Kozhikode, Kannur, and Kasaragod. This regional pattern highlights the cultural uniqueness and diversity of megalithic practices in Kerala.

Kodakkal (Umbrella Stone)

Kodakkal, popularly known as the Umbrella Stone, is one of the most distinctive and unique types of megalithic monuments found in Kerala. The name “Kodakkal” is derived from the Malayalam words kuda (umbrella) and kal (stone), referring to its characteristic umbrella-like appearance. This form of megalith is particularly significant because it is largely confined to Kerala and is rarely found elsewhere in India, making it an important marker of regional cultural identity during the Iron Age and Early Historic period. Kodakkals are primarily made of laterite stone, a material that is abundantly available in the northern parts of Kerala. Laterite is relatively soft when freshly quarried, allowing it to be shaped into desired forms, but it hardens upon exposure, making it durable for long-term use. The structure of a Kodakkal typically consists of two main components. The upper part is a large, dome-shaped or semi-circular capstone, which resembles the top of an umbrella. This capstone usually has a flat or slightly convex underside. The lower part consists of three or four upright stone slabs that act as supporting pillars, holding the capstone in position and creating a chamber-like space beneath.

Geographically, Kodakkals are mainly distributed in the districts of Thrissur, Palakkad, Malappuram, Kozhikode, and Kannur, indicating a strong concentration in northern Kerala. Important sites such as Ariyannur and Cheramanangad in Thrissur district preserve clusters of these monuments, some of which have been protected and maintained by the Archaeological Survey of India. Excavations at sites like Perambra in Kozhikode and Anakkara in Palakkad have revealed valuable archaeological materials associated with Kodakkals. These excavations have unearthed burial assemblages, including Black and Red Ware pottery, iron implements, bronze objects, and bone fragments. Such findings confirm that Kodakkals were used as burial monuments, particularly for secondary burials where the remains of the deceased were placed after cremation or decomposition. The presence of grave goods indicates a belief in an afterlife and reflects the material culture, technological advancement, and social practices of the megalithic people. Thus, Kodakkal monuments are not merely architectural structures but serve as crucial evidence for understanding the burial customs, belief systems, and Iron Age culture of ancient Kerala.

Thoppikkal (Capstone)

Thoppikkal, commonly known as the Capstone, is an important type of megalithic monument found in Kerala. It is named after its distinctive appearance, as the structure resembles a “thoppi” (cap) placed over the ground. The term “Thoppikkal” itself reflects this cap-like shape, which makes it easily identifiable among other megalithic forms. This type of monument is particularly associated with the burial practices of the Iron Age and Early Historic societies of Kerala. Thoppikkals are primarily made of laterite stone, a material that is abundantly available in the region. Laterite is relatively soft when quarried, making it easier to shape into semi-circular or dome-like forms, and it hardens upon exposure, ensuring durability. The structure of a Thoppikkal consists of a large semi-circular capstone placed above the ground surface. Unlike other megalithic monuments where multiple structural elements are visible, in the case of Thoppikkal, only the top stone is seen on the surface. The actual burial remains are located beneath the ground, usually inside a large urn or pit that contains the burial assemblage.

The burial associated with Thoppikkal typically includes urn burials, where the remains of the deceased—often in the form of bone fragments—are placed inside large terracotta urns. Along with the human remains, various grave goods such as pottery, iron implements, beads, and other objects were deposited. These items indicate the belief of the megalithic people in an afterlife and provide valuable insights into their material culture, technological advancement, and social practices. The study of Thoppikkal dates back to the early nineteenth century, when J. Babington

conducted excavations in 1819 at Chettapparamba near Kozhikode. Although he referred to these monuments as “Pandukoolis,” his work was crucial in bringing scholarly attention to megalithic burials in South India. Subsequent archaeological investigations have further enhanced our understanding of these structures.

One of the important sites where a cluster of Thoppikkals has been preserved is Cheramanangad in Thrissur district, which is protected by the Archaeological Survey of India. Such preserved sites help in studying the original context and distribution of these monuments. In short, Thoppikkal is a significant megalithic form that represents the burial customs of ancient Kerala. It not only reflects the funerary practices of the time but also provides important evidence for understanding the cultural and historical background of the Iron Age society.

Rock-cut Chambers

Rock-cut Chambers are one of the most remarkable types of megalithic monuments found in Kerala, representing an advanced stage in burial architecture during the Iron Age and Early Historic period. These chambers are burial chambers carved directly into laterite formations, such as plateaus, hillocks, and slopes. Unlike surface-level megaliths, rock-cut chambers involve cutting into natural rock, demonstrating a higher level of technical skill and planning among the megalithic communities. There are two main types of rock-cut chambers: single-chambered and multi-chambered structures. The single-chamber chamber is relatively simple in design. It consists of a single burial chamber carved into the rock, often with a porthole opening at the top, which is covered with a stone lid. This opening might have been used to place the remains or offerings into the chamber. In some cases, a central pillar is also present within the chamber, possibly to support the roof or for ritual purposes.

The multi-chamber rock-cut chamber is more complex and architecturally refined. It typically features a well-finished square or arched entrance, which is closed with a stone door. In front of the entrance, there is often a passage or corridor, leading into one or more burial chambers. Inside these chambers, stone benches or platforms are sometimes found, which may have been used to place the remains of the deceased or associated grave goods. The presence of multiple chambers suggests that these structures could have been used for family or collective burials over a period of time.

Important excavations of rock-cut chambers have been carried out at sites such as Porkalam and Kandanasseri in Thrissur district, and Ummichipoyil in Kasaragod district. These excavations have provided valuable archaeological evidence, including burial remains and associated artefacts, helping scholars reconstruct the burial customs and material culture of the megalithic period. Rock-cut chambers are widely distributed in northern Kerala, particularly in districts like Thrissur, Malappuram, Kozhikode, Kannur, and Kasaragod, with a higher concentration in Kozhikode, Kannur, and Kasaragod regions. Their widespread occurrence indicates the importance of this burial tradition in the region. In short, rock-cut chambers reflect a high degree of architectural sophistication and cultural development. They provide crucial insights into the funerary practices, social organization, and technological capabilities of the megalithic society in Kerala.

Stone Circles (Kalvalayam)

Stone circles, locally known as Kalvalayam, are an important type of megalithic burial monument found in South India, especially in Kerala. These monuments consist of stones arranged in a circular pattern, marking the burial site of the dead. They are among the most visible and easily identifiable forms of megalithic structures and play a crucial role in understanding the burial practices and cultural life of the Iron Age and Early Historic societies. In Kerala, stone circles are

constructed using two main types of materials: granite boulders and laterite stone slabs. The granite stone circles are more widespread and can be found across almost all regions of Kerala. These are usually made of rough, unshaped granite stones placed upright in a circular formation. On the other hand, the laterite stone circles are a unique feature of northern Kerala, where well-dressed and carefully shaped laterite slabs are used. The use of laterite reflects the adaptation of local materials and the technological skill of the megalithic builders.

Stone circles are not merely surface markers; they usually enclose various types of burial structures within them. Inside these circles, archaeologists have discovered cist burials, urn burials, and rock-cut chambers, indicating that the circle functioned as a boundary or protective enclosure for the burial. This suggests a well-organized funerary system, where the dead were carefully interred along with associated structures and grave goods. Several important examples highlight the diversity of stone circles in Kerala. At Naduvil in Kannur district, a stone circle has been found enclosing a rock-cut chamber, showing a combination of two different megalithic forms. Similarly, at Anakkara in Palakkad district, laterite stone circles have revealed both rock-cut chambers and urn burials within them. In regions like Wayanad, particularly at Ambalavayal and Ambukuthi, stone circles often contain granite cist burials, further demonstrating the variety of burial practices associated with this monument type.

The widespread distribution of stone circles across Kerala, along with their association with different burial forms, indicates their importance in megalithic culture. They reflect not only the funerary customs of the time but also the social organization and ritual practices of early communities. Thus, stone circles (Kalvalayam) serve as significant archaeological evidence for reconstructing the burial traditions and cultural landscape of ancient Kerala.

Cist Burial

Cist burials are one of the most common and characteristic forms of megalithic burial monuments found in South India, including Kerala. A cist is essentially a box-shaped burial chamber constructed using four large granite slabs placed vertically to form the sides of a rectangular enclosure. These slabs are carefully arranged and the chamber is usually covered with a flat stone slab, creating a closed burial structure beneath the ground surface. Unlike some other megalithic monuments that are visible above the ground, cist burials are typically subterranean, meaning they are buried underground. Only a small portion, such as the capstone or marker stones, may sometimes be visible on the surface. The use of granite, a hard and durable material, indicates the technical skill and effort involved in quarrying, transporting, and assembling these heavy stone slabs.

One of the distinctive features of cist burials is the presence of a porthole, usually located on one of the vertical slabs. This porthole is often aligned in the east–west direction and may have been used for placing the remains or offerings into the chamber. In some cases, the porthole is fitted with a stone plug or door, which could be opened and closed. This suggests that the burial chamber might have been accessed more than once, possibly for repeated rituals or for depositing additional remains. Cist burials are most commonly found in the highland regions of Kerala, where granite is abundantly available. Major concentrations of these burials have been reported from districts such as Idukki, Wayanad, and Palakkad. Their distribution reflects the adaptation of megalithic communities to the natural resources of their environment.

Important archaeological excavations have provided valuable insights into cist burials. At Kadanad in Kottayam district, excavations carried out by the Archaeological Survey of India uncovered a large number of artefacts within cist burials. These included iron implements, pottery (such as Black and Red Ware), and other grave goods. The presence of such objects indicates the

technological advancement of the megalithic people, especially their knowledge of iron metallurgy, as well as their belief in an afterlife where these items might be of use. In short, cist burials are significant not only as burial structures but also as important sources of archaeological information. They provide valuable evidence for understanding the burial practices, material culture, and social life of the megalithic communities in Kerala.

Dolmen

Dolmens are a prominent type of megalithic monument found in Kerala and across South India. A dolmen is an above-ground burial chamber constructed using large stone slabs. Typically, it consists of two or more vertical stones supporting a large, flat horizontal slab that acts as a roof, giving it a table-like appearance. Unlike cist burials, which are buried underground, dolmens are clearly visible on the surface, making them one of the most striking forms of megalithic architecture. Structurally, dolmens are quite similar to cists in that both are made of stone slabs forming a chamber.

However, the key difference is that cists are subterranean, while dolmens are erected above the ground. Inside the dolmen chamber, the remains of the deceased along with various grave goods such as pottery, iron implements, and beads were placed. These objects provide important clues about the material culture and technological advancement of the megalithic people. In South India, both primary (full skeleton) and secondary (bone fragments) burials have been identified in dolmens. However, in the context of Kerala, archaeological evidence suggests that dolmens were mainly used for secondary burials, where only the collected bone fragments of the deceased were deposited after cremation or natural decomposition. This indicates specific funerary practices and beliefs related to death and the afterlife.

Dolmens are widely distributed in the granite-rich highland regions of Kerala. They are commonly found in districts such as Thrissur, Palakkad, Idukki, and Wayanad. One of the most important dolmen sites in Kerala is Marayur in Idukki district, which has a large concentration of well-preserved dolmens. Many dolmens are also located in the surrounding areas of the famous Edakkal region in Wayanad, further highlighting the importance of these highland zones in megalithic culture. Among local communities, dolmens are often referred to as “Muniyara,” meaning the dwelling place of sages or saints. This reflects a popular belief that these structures were once inhabited by holy men. However, this is a mythical interpretation and does not have any historical or archaeological basis. In reality, dolmens are burial monuments that provide valuable insights into the funerary customs and social practices of ancient societies. Thus, dolmens are significant not only as architectural structures but also as key archaeological sources for understanding the burial traditions, beliefs, and cultural life of the megalithic people in Kerala.

Menhir

Menhirs are an important category of megalithic monuments found in Kerala and across South India. A menhir is a tall, upright stone slab or pillar that is placed vertically into the ground. Unlike other megalithic structures such as cists or dolmens, menhirs are generally not burial chambers. Instead, they function primarily as memorial stones, erected in honour of individuals, particularly warriors or heroes who died in battle or performed notable deeds. In Kerala, menhirs are known by various local names such as Nadukkal, Pulachikkal, and Ottakkal. The term Nadukkal is especially significant in the cultural context of South India, as it is often associated with hero stones commemorating brave individuals. These monuments reflect the social values of the time, where acts of bravery and sacrifice were publicly remembered and honoured through the erection of such stones.

Menhirs are typically made of granite or laterite, depending on the availability of local materials. Granite menhirs are more common in highland regions, while laterite menhirs are found in areas where laterite is abundant. The stones are usually large and unshaped or roughly dressed, and they are firmly embedded in the ground to ensure stability. Some menhirs are plain, while others feature carved figures or symbols, often depicting warriors, weapons, or scenes of battle. These carvings provide valuable insights into the artistic expression and symbolic traditions of the megalithic people. The primary purpose of menhirs is commemorative rather than funerary. They were erected to mark the memory of important individuals and to preserve their legacy within the community. In some cases, menhirs may also have served as territorial markers or symbols of social identity, indicating the presence or influence of a particular group.

A notable example of a menhir in Kerala is found at Thirunavaya in Malappuram district, where a large laterite menhir has been reported. Such examples highlight the continued importance of these monuments in understanding the cultural landscape of ancient Kerala. To conclude, menhirs are significant not only as physical structures but also as expressions of social memory and cultural values. They provide important evidence for understanding the commemorative practices, belief systems, and artistic traditions of the megalithic society in Kerala.

Urn Burial

Urn burial is one of the most common and widespread megalithic burial practices found in Kerala and across South India. This type of burial involves the use of a large terracotta pot (urn) in which the remains of the deceased are placed. These urns are usually handmade and relatively coarse in finish, with thick rims and a pointed or rounded base. They were typically buried in pits dug into the ground, either singly or in clusters, depending on the burial practice of the community.
A key feature of urn burials is that they are generally associated with secondary burial practices. In this method, the body of the deceased was first cremated or left to decompose naturally. After this process, the bone fragments were collected and placed inside the urn. Along with these remains, various grave goods such as pottery, iron implements, beads, and ornaments were also included. The presence of these objects suggests that the megalithic people believed in an afterlife, where such items might be needed by the deceased.

Another important characteristic of urn burials is the preparation of the interior of the urn. Often, a layer of sand or soil was placed at the base of the urn before depositing the bone fragments and objects. This sand bed may have served both practical and ritual purposes, such as protecting the remains or symbolizing purification. After placing the contents inside, the urn was usually covered with a lid, which could be made of terracotta or stone, ensuring that the burial remained sealed. Urn burials are not always found in isolation. In many cases, they occur in association with other megalithic structures such as cists, dolmens, stone circles, and capstones (Thoppikkal). This indicates a complex and varied funerary system in which different types of burial practices coexisted.

Archaeological excavations at sites like Anakkara in Palakkad have revealed urn burials with sand beds and associated artefacts, providing valuable insights into these practices. In Kerala, urn burials are known by several local names, including Nannangadi, Muthumakkathazhi, and Anjanadikkudam. These names reflect the familiarity of local communities with these ancient burial forms, even before formal archaeological studies began. Thus, urn burials are highly significant for understanding the burial customs, belief systems, and material culture of the megalithic society in Kerala.

Sarcophagus (Terracotta Coffin Burial)

The sarcophagus is a distinctive type of megalithic burial monument characterized by the use of a terracotta coffin for interment. Unlike stone-built structures such as cists or dolmens, the sarcophagus is made of baked clay (terracotta) and functions as a container for the remains of the deceased. It represents an important variation within the megalithic burial tradition of South India and provides valuable insights into the diversity of funerary practices during the Iron Age and Early Historic period. Sarcophagi may occur independently or in association with other megalithic structures such as dolmens, cists, and rock-cut chambers. This suggests that different burial types were often used together within the same cultural context, reflecting a complex and varied system of mortuary practices. In many cases, the sarcophagus served as the primary container for the burial, while the surrounding structures functioned as protective or commemorative elements.

One of the notable features of sarcophagi is their construction. They are usually handmade and fired in kilns, resulting in a durable terracotta structure. Some sarcophagi are designed with legs, known as “legged sarcophagi,” which elevate the coffin slightly above the ground level within the burial pit or chamber. This feature may have had symbolic or practical significance, possibly related to ritual beliefs or the protection of the remains. The interior of the sarcophagus typically contains bone fragments, indicating secondary burial practices, along with various grave goods such as pottery, iron implements, beads, and ornaments. These inclusions reflect the belief in an afterlife and provide evidence of the material culture of the megalithic people.

In terms of distribution, sarcophagi are relatively rare in Kerala compared to their wider presence in Tamil Nadu, where they are more commonly found. However, a few important examples have been reported in Kerala. Sites such as Perunkulam and Kattakambal in Thrissur district, and Farook, Chevayur, and Koyilandy in Kozhikode district, have yielded sarcophagus burials, including examples found within rock-cut chambers. These discoveries highlight regional variations and interactions within South Indian megalithic culture. The presence of sarcophagi in Kerala indicates cultural connections and shared burial traditions with neighbouring regions, especially Tamil Nadu. At the same time, their limited occurrence suggests local adaptations and selective use of this burial form. Thus, sarcophagus burials are significant for understanding the diversity of burial practices, technological skills, and cultural interactions of the megalithic society in South India.

Conclusion

Megaliths are not just stone structures; they are valuable historical sources that help us reconstruct the early past of Kerala. Through these monuments, we understand how people of the Iron Age lived, how they treated their dead. The different types of megaliths—such as cists, dolmens, menhirs, stone circles, urn burials, and sarcophagi—show that there was diversity in burial practices and a well-developed cultural tradition. The use of materials like laterite, granite, and terracotta also reflects the adaptation to local resources and technological skills. Moreover, the presence of grave goods such as pottery, iron tools, and ornaments indicates a belief in an afterlife and highlights the economic and social conditions of that period. Thus, the study of megaliths and their typology is essential for understanding the archaeological, cultural, and historical development of Kerala and South India.

Grave goods in Megaliths

Grave goods refer to the objects that were placed along with the dead in burial contexts. These items are not random; they were carefully selected and deposited as part of funerary rituals. The presence of these objects clearly shows that the megalithic people had a strong belief in life after death, and they thought the deceased would need these materials in the next world. In Kerala, grave goods are extremely important because they serve as primary archaeological evidence for understanding early history, especially in the absence of written records. Through these materials, we can reconstruct the daily life, occupation, technology, and social structure of ancient communities.

Grave goods in megaliths can be broadly classified into four main categories: Pottery, Metal objects, Beads and Bone fragments. Among them the pottery is known to be the most common grave good, which includes different types like Black and Red Ware, Red Ware etc. While the metal objects include iron tools and weapons, beads are generally made of semi-precious stones and glass. Similarly, bone fragments, reflect different burial practices existed here. Each of these categories provides unique insights into the socio - cultural life and technological development of the megalithic people.

Grave goods form an essential component of megalithic culture and provide valuable insights into the beliefs, practices, and lifestyle of the people who lived during the Iron Age and Early Historic period in Kerala. The presence of grave goods indicates that the megalithic communities had a strong belief in life after death, where the deceased might require these objects in the next world. Thus, burial was not merely a disposal of the body, but a ritual act reflecting spiritual and cultural values.

Grave goods are important for archaeologists because they serve as direct evidence of material culture and technological advancement. Since written records are not available for this period, these objects help reconstruct various aspects of ancient society, including occupation, trade, craftsmanship, and social hierarchy. The types and quality of goods found in burials may also indicate the status or importance of the individual buried. In Kerala, megalithic grave goods can be broadly classified into four main categories: pottery, metal objects, beads, and bone fragments. Among these, pottery is the most commonly found and significant. Different types such as Black and Red Ware, Red Slipped Ware, and Russet Coated Painted Ware have been discovered from various burial sites. These pottery items include bowls, jars, lids, and stands, reflecting both functional and ritual use.

The second category includes metal objects, particularly those made of iron. These consist of weapons like swords, daggers, and spearheads, as well as tools such as axes, sickles, and ploughshares. The presence of such items shows the development of iron technology and suggests their use in warfare, agriculture, and daily life. Occasionally, objects made of bronze, copper, and even gold have also been found, though they are relatively rare. Beads form another important category of grave goods. These are made from semi-precious stones like carnelian, quartz, and agate, as well as glass and terracotta. Their presence indicates a developed sense of ornamentation and possible trade connections with other regions. Bone fragments are commonly found in megalithic burials in Kerala, reflecting the practice of secondary burial. These remains, along with the associated objects, help in understanding burial rituals and beliefs. Thus, grave goods play a crucial role in reconstructing the cultural, technological, and social life of megalithic Kerala.

Pottery

Pottery is considered the most important and abundant grave good found in megalithic burials in Kerala and across South India. It is present in almost all types of burials, including urn burials, cists, dolmens, rock-cut chambers, and stone circles. Due to its durability and widespread occurrence, pottery serves as a key source of archaeological evidence for understanding the cultural and technological aspects of the megalithic period. One of the most significant types of pottery found in megalithic contexts is the Black and Red Ware (BRW). This pottery is regarded as a hallmark of the Iron Age in South India. It is characterized by its distinctive colouring—black on the inner surface and rim, and red on the outer surface. This effect was achieved through an advanced firing technique, often involving inverted and upright firing methods that controlled the oxygen supply during the process. The presence of BRW at various sites indicates a high level of technological skill among the megalithic potters.

Another important category is the Red Slipped Ware, which is often found in large quantities in burial sites. This pottery is coated with a fine red slip, giving it a smooth and polished appearance. It includes various forms such as jars, bowls, and dishes, and was likely used for both daily and ritual purposes. Black Ware is also found, though in smaller quantities compared to BRW and Red Slipped Ware. It is usually plain and functional in design, suggesting its use in everyday activities as well as in burial contexts. A later and significant type is the Russet Coated Painted Ware (RCPW). This pottery is distinguished by its russet coating and painted designs. It is believed to belong to the early historic period and is often associated with trade connections, as it may have been introduced from regions like Andhra. The discovery of RCPW in Kerala suggests interaction and exchange between different cultural regions.

Megalithic pottery also includes a variety of forms such as plates, bowls, lids, jars, and stands. Some of these vessels bear graffiti marks, which may represent symbols, ownership marks, or religious signs. These markings provide additional insight into the symbolic and communicative practices of the time. Thus, pottery not only reflects the daily life and artistic skills of the megalithic people but also plays a crucial role in understanding their technology, trade, and cultural identity.

Black & Red Ware (BRW)

Black and Red Ware (BRW) is one of the most distinctive and widely recognized types of pottery associated with the Iron Age in South India, including Kerala. It is often described as the hallmark of megalithic pottery, as its presence is a key indicator of Iron Age cultural contexts in archaeological sites. The pottery is easily identifiable by its unique colour combination—black on the inner surface and rim, and red on the outer surface—which gives it a striking and characteristic appearance. The production of Black and Red Ware reflects a high level of technological advancement among the megalithic potters. This distinctive colour pattern was achieved through an advanced firing technique, commonly known as the inverted and upright firing method. In this process, the pots were carefully arranged in a kiln in such a way that different parts of the vessel were exposed to varying levels of oxygen. The black portion resulted from a reduced oxygen environment, while the red portion was produced in an oxidized atmosphere. This controlled firing technique required considerable skill and knowledge of temperature and air regulation, demonstrating the technical expertise of ancient craftsmen.

Black and Red Ware has been discovered at several important archaeological sites in Kerala. Notable examples include Chettapparamba in Kozhikode district, Porkkalam in Thrissur district, and Anakkara in Palakkad district. Excavations at these sites have yielded a variety of BRW forms

such as bowls, dishes, jars, and lids, often found in association with other burial goods like iron tools and beads. These findings confirm the widespread use of BRW in megalithic burial practices. The presence of Black and Red Ware in burial contexts suggests that these vessels had both functional and ritual significance. They may have been used to store food or offerings for the deceased, indicating a belief in life after death. At the same time, their careful placement within graves reflects the symbolic importance attached to pottery in funerary customs. In short, Black and Red Ware is not only an important archaeological marker of the Iron Age but also a reflection of the technological skill, cultural practices, and belief systems of the megalithic people in Kerala.

Other Pottery Types

Apart from the well-known Black and Red Ware, several other types of pottery have been discovered in megalithic burials in Kerala. These pottery types are equally important for understanding the cultural, technological, and economic aspects of the megalithic period. Among them, Red Slipped Ware and Russet Coated Painted Ware (RCPW) are particularly significant. Red Slipped Ware is one of the most commonly found pottery types in megalithic burial sites, often discovered in large quantities. This pottery is characterized by a fine red coating or "slip" applied to the surface, which gives it a smooth and polished appearance. It includes a variety of forms such as jars, bowls, dishes, and storage vessels. The widespread presence of Red Slipped Ware suggests that it was used both in daily life and in burial rituals. Its fine finish also indicates a certain level of aesthetic sense and craftsmanship among the potters.

Another important category is the Russet Coated Painted Ware (RCPW), sometimes referred to as Andhra Ware. This pottery is distinguished by its russet-coloured coating and painted designs, often in geometric or linear patterns. Chronologically, RCPW is considered to belong to a later phase, likely the Early Historic period, and is generally dated after the Black and Red Ware phase. The presence of RCPW in Kerala is particularly significant because it is believed to have been imported from the Andhra region, suggesting the existence of long-distance trade connections and cultural exchanges between different parts of South India. An interesting feature observed in many megalithic pottery pieces is the presence of graffiti marks. These are symbols or markings incised or painted on the surface of the pottery, often before firing. While their exact meaning is still debated, they are believed to represent ownership marks, clan symbols, religious signs, or identifiers of the potter or the deceased. These markings provide valuable clues about communication, symbolism, and identity in megalithic society. Thus, the study of these other pottery types reveals not only the variety and sophistication of ceramic traditions but also highlights aspects of trade, cultural interaction, and symbolic expression in ancient Kerala.

Iron Objects

Iron objects form the second most important category of grave goods found in megalithic burials in Kerala and across South India, next only to pottery. Their presence is especially significant because they clearly indicate that these societies belonged to the Iron Age, a period marked by the widespread use of iron for various purposes. The discovery of iron objects in burial contexts provides valuable evidence about the technological advancement, economic activities, and daily life of the megalithic people. A wide variety of iron objects has been unearthed from different burial sites. These include weapons, which reflect the martial aspects of society. Common weapons found in megalithic graves are swords, daggers, spearheads, arrowheads, and tridents. The inclusion of such weapons in burials suggests that warfare or hunting played an important role in their lives, and that individuals may have been buried with objects that symbolized their identity, status, or profession.

In addition to weapons, many tools and implements related to agriculture and craftsmanship have also been discovered. These include axes, chisels, ploughshares, and sickles. The presence of agricultural tools indicates that farming was a major occupation, while tools like chisels point to activities such as woodworking or stone working. This demonstrates that the megalithic people had a well-developed knowledge of iron metallurgy and used it effectively in various aspects of life. Iron objects used for household purposes have also been found in burial sites. These include items such as lamps, tripods, and other domestic implements. Such objects suggest that everyday life and domestic activities were also symbolically represented in burial practices, reinforcing the belief that the deceased would continue a similar existence in the afterlife.

The craftsmanship seen in these iron objects reflects a high level of skill in metalworking, including forging, shaping, and finishing. The ability to produce a wide range of tools and weapons indicates not only technological expertise but also an organized society with specialized skills. To conclude, iron objects are crucial for understanding the technological progress, economic activities, and social structure of megalithic Kerala. They highlight the importance of iron in shaping both the material culture and daily life of ancient communities.

Bronze, Copper & Gold

Along with iron, other metals such as bronze, copper, and gold have also been discovered in megalithic burials in Kerala, though they are comparatively rare. The limited occurrence of these metals makes them particularly significant, as they often indicate special status, wealth, or cultural connections of the individuals buried with them. While iron objects reflect everyday life and practical use, these metals are usually associated with ornamental, ritual, or high-value items. Bronze objects are among the more commonly reported non-iron metal finds in Kerala's megalithic contexts, though still not abundant. These include items such as vessels, lamps, and utensils, which may have been used for domestic or ritual purposes. A notable example is a bronze vase discovered at Naduvil in Kannur district, which reflects both craftsmanship and the use of metal in ceremonial contexts. Other findings include fragments of bronze objects, such as lids and decorative items, from various excavation sites.

Copper objects are even rarer and are usually found in fragmentary or corroded conditions due to long-term burial. These objects are not always easily identifiable, but their presence suggests that copper was known and occasionally used by the megalithic people. Copper may have been used either independently or as part of alloy production, such as in the making of bronze. Gold objects are the rarest among the metal grave goods found in Kerala. However, a few important discoveries have been made, such as gold ornaments from sites like Arippa in Kollam district and Naduvil in Kannur district. These include items like beads or small ornaments, which were likely used as personal adornments. The presence of gold in burials strongly suggests that the individual may have belonged to a higher social or economic status.

The occurrence of bronze, copper, and gold objects in megalithic burials highlights the existence of metallurgical knowledge and trade networks, as some of these materials may not have been locally available. These items also reflect a sense of aesthetic appreciation and social differentiation within the community. Thus, although rare, these metal objects provide important insights into the wealth, status, craftsmanship, and cultural connections of the megalithic society in Kerala.

Beads

Beads are one of the most significant and frequently discovered grave goods in megalithic burials in Kerala and other parts of South India. They are often found in large numbers, sometimes

in clusters or as part of ornaments placed with the deceased. The abundance of beads in burial contexts highlights their importance not only as decorative items but also as objects with social, cultural, and possibly ritual significance. Megalithic beads were made from a wide variety of materials, especially semi-precious stones. Common materials include carnelian, quartz, agate, amethyst, steatite, and beryl. Among these, carnelian beads, particularly etched carnelian, are highly notable due to their fine craftsmanship and distinctive designs. In addition to stone beads, glass beads and terracotta beads have also been discovered, though usually in smaller quantities. The use of such diverse materials indicates a high level of skill in bead-making and an understanding of different raw materials.

Important archaeological sites in Kerala have yielded significant quantities of beads. For example, excavations at Porkkalam in Thrissur district uncovered a large number of etched carnelian beads, including a burial urn that contained dozens of such pieces. Similarly, the site of Anakkara in Palakkad district has produced a considerable number of beads made from semi-precious stones. These findings suggest that beads were commonly used as part of burial offerings and may have been worn by the deceased during life. The presence of beads in megalithic burials provides valuable insights into the ornamentation practices of the people. They likely formed part of necklaces, bracelets, or other personal adornments, indicating a developed sense of aesthetics and personal identity. Moreover, since some materials like carnelian and glass may not have been locally available, their presence points to the existence of trade networks and cultural interactions with other regions, possibly including distant parts of India. In short, beads are not just decorative objects but important archaeological evidence that helps us understand the craftsmanship, trade connections, and social life of the megalithic communities in Kerala.

Bone Remains

Bone remains form an important category of evidence in the study of megalithic burials in Kerala. Unlike some other regions of South India where complete human skeletons have been discovered, the megalithic sites of Kerala have mostly yielded bone fragments rather than full skeletons. This distinctive feature is closely related to the type of burial practices followed by the megalithic communities in this region. The majority of burials in Kerala belong to the secondary burial type. In this practice, the body of the deceased was not buried immediately in its complete form. Instead, the body was either cremated (burnt) or left exposed to natural elements for decomposition. After this process, the remaining bone fragments were carefully collected and placed inside burial containers such as urns, cists, dolmens, or rock-cut chambers. This explains why archaeologists usually find only fragments of bones rather than complete skeletons in these burial sites.

Important archaeological sites in Kerala have provided clear evidence of such practices. At Anakkara in Palakkad district, excavations of urn burials have revealed a large quantity of bone fragments, often mixed with sand or soil inside the urn. Similarly, at Arippa in Kollam district, cist burials have yielded both human and animal bone fragments, indicating that animals might also have been part of burial rituals or offerings. These findings help us understand the nature of funerary customs and the rituals associated with death in megalithic society. The absence of full skeletons in Kerala contrasts with sites like Adichanallur in Tamil Nadu, where primary burials with complete skeletons have been found. This difference highlights regional variations in burial practices within South India and suggests that cultural traditions and beliefs about death and the afterlife differed from place to place.

The study of bone remains is important not only for understanding burial customs but also for gaining insights into the biological aspects of past populations, such as age, health, diet, and sometimes even cause of death. However, in Kerala, the fragmented and often poorly preserved

condition of bones—due to factors like heavy rainfall, soil acidity, and long-term burial—makes such analysis more challenging. In conclusion, bone remains, though fragmentary, are crucial archaeological evidence that reflect the secondary burial practices, ritual beliefs, and cultural patterns of the megalithic people in Kerala.

Preservation Issues

The preservation of megalithic materials in Kerala presents significant challenges for archaeologists. Many of the artefacts recovered from burial sites—such as pottery, metal objects, beads, and bone fragments—are often found in a damaged, weathered, or highly deteriorated condition. This makes the study and interpretation of these materials more difficult and sometimes limits the amount of information that can be extracted from them. One of the primary reasons for this poor preservation is the heavy rainfall characteristic of Kerala's climate. The region experiences intense monsoon rains for a large part of the year, which leads to high levels of soil moisture. Continuous exposure to water causes erosion and chemical changes in the soil, which can gradually damage buried artefacts. For example, pottery may become fragile and break easily, while iron objects often undergo severe corrosion, losing their original shape and details over time.

Another important factor is the undulating terrain of Kerala. The landscape, especially in regions like Wayanad, Idukki, and parts of Palakkad, consists of hills, slopes, and uneven surfaces. Such terrain is prone to soil erosion and landslides, which can disturb or displace megalithic structures and burial contexts. As a result, artefacts may be scattered, broken, or removed from their original positions, making it difficult for archaeologists to reconstruct the burial accurately. In addition to natural factors, continuous human activity has also contributed to the deterioration of megalithic sites. Kerala has been densely inhabited for centuries, and activities such as agriculture, construction, road building, and urban expansion have often led to the disturbance or destruction of burial sites. In many cases, megalithic monuments have been unknowingly damaged or removed during land use, leading to the loss of valuable archaeological evidence.

Furthermore, repeated handling and exposure after excavation can also affect the condition of artefacts if proper conservation measures are not followed. The combined impact of environmental and human factors means that many megalithic materials survive only in fragmentary form. In conclusion, preservation issues are a major challenge in the study of megaliths in Kerala. Understanding these factors is essential for developing better conservation strategies and ensuring that the remaining archaeological heritage is protected for future research.

Significance of Grave Goods

Grave goods are one of the most valuable sources of information for understanding the megalithic culture of Kerala. These are the objects placed along with the dead in burial contexts, and they provide deep insights into the beliefs, technology, economy, and social structure of early societies. Since written records are almost absent for this period, archaeologists rely heavily on these material remains to reconstruct the history of ancient Kerala. One of the most important aspects revealed by grave goods is the belief in an afterlife. The practice of placing objects such as pottery, tools, ornaments, and food containers in burials suggests that the megalithic people believed that life continued after death. These items were probably meant to serve the needs of the deceased in the next world. This indicates a developed system of religious or spiritual beliefs and rituals associated with death.

Grave goods also help us understand the technological advancement of the megalithic society. The presence of well-made pottery like Black and Red Ware, along with a variety of iron tools and weapons, shows that these people had advanced knowledge of pottery-making and iron metallurgy. The ability to produce and use such objects reflects a high level of skill and innovation. At the same time, these artefacts give clues about the economic activities of the people, such as agriculture, hunting, and craftsmanship. Another important aspect highlighted by grave goods is the social status and hierarchy within the community. The quantity and quality of items found in a burial can indicate the importance or rank of the individual. For example, burials containing rare items like gold ornaments or finely crafted objects may belong to individuals of higher status, while simpler burials may represent common people.

Grave goods also provide evidence of trade and cultural interactions. The presence of materials such as carnelian beads or Russet Coated Painted Ware, which may have originated outside Kerala, suggests the existence of trade networks and connections with other regions of South India and beyond. In short, grave goods are a key archaeological source for reconstructing the early history of Kerala. They offer a comprehensive understanding of the cultural life, beliefs, economy, and social organization of the megalithic people. Grave goods are not just objects buried with the dead; they are valuable historical sources that help us understand the life and culture of the megalithic people. Through these materials, we gain insights into their belief in the afterlife, their technological knowledge, and their economic activities.

The presence of pottery, iron tools, beads, and other materials shows that the megalithic society was technologically advanced and culturally rich. At the same time, variations in the quantity and quality of grave goods indicate social differences and hierarchy within the community. Moreover, certain materials such as semi-precious stone beads and special types of pottery suggest the existence of trade networks and cultural interactions with other regions. Therefore, the study of grave goods plays a crucial role in reconstructing the early history of Kerala, helping us understand not only how people lived, but also how they viewed human death etc.

Megalithic Excavation

The Megalithic excavations open a window into the life of people who lived in Kerala during the Iron Age, roughly from 1000 BCE onwards. Megalithic monuments such as urn burials, stone circles, dolmens, and umbrella stones are not just stone structures. They are powerful archaeological evidence that help us understand the beliefs, technology, economy, and social organisation of early human communities. Through major excavation sites like Chattaparamba, Porkalam, Mangadu, Ummichipoyil, and Anakkara, archaeologists have uncovered valuable artefacts such as iron tools, pottery, beads, and human remains. Each site contributes uniquely to our understanding of how ancient societies lived, worked, and buried their dead. These discoveries also show that early Kerala was not an isolated region. Instead, it was part of wider cultural and trade networks within the Indian subcontinent. Most importantly, these excavations help us trace the gradual transition from the Stone Age to the Iron Age, marking a major shift in human history.

Introduction to Megaliths

Megaliths are large stone structures that were primarily used as burial monuments by ancient communities. The term “megalith” is derived from two Greek words: mega meaning large and lithos meaning stone. These monuments are significant archaeological remains that help us understand the cultural and social life of early human societies. In Kerala, megaliths are widely distributed and form an important part of the region’s early history. Megaliths in Kerala belong mainly to the Iron Age, a period marked by the widespread use of iron tools and implements. This phase roughly dates from around 1000 BCE onwards. The introduction of iron technology brought significant changes in agriculture, warfare, and daily life, which is clearly reflected in the materials found within these burial sites. Iron weapons, agricultural tools, and other implements discovered from megalithic graves indicate a society that had advanced technical knowledge and skill in metal usage.

These monuments are found across various parts of Kerala, especially in regions with laterite soil and undulating terrain. Different types of megalithic structures have been identified, such as umbrella stones (kudakkallu), capstones (topikkallu), dolmens, rock-cut caves, and urn burials. Each type reflects variations in burial practices and regional adaptations. The presence of such diverse burial forms suggests that megalithic culture was widespread and well-developed across the region. Megaliths provide valuable evidence about the beliefs and practices of early societies. The inclusion of grave goods such as pottery, beads, iron tools, and sometimes food items indicates a belief in life after death. People believed that the deceased would require these items in the afterlife. The variety and richness of these objects also suggest differences in social status, pointing towards the existence of social hierarchy.

Furthermore, megaliths offer insights into the economic life of the people. The discovery of agricultural tools indicates that farming was an important occupation, while the presence of semi-precious stone beads like carnelian suggests trade connections with other regions of India. Thus, megalithic monuments are not merely burial sites but are crucial sources for reconstructing the early history, culture, technology, and economy of Kerala.

Important Megalithic Excavation Sites in Kerala

Kerala has several important megalithic excavation sites that provide crucial evidence for understanding the Iron Age culture and early history of the region. These sites reveal burial practices, material culture, and socio-economic life of ancient communities. One of the earliest and most significant sites is Chattaparamba (Farook) in Kozhikode district. This site gained prominence

through the work of J. Babington in the early 19th century. Excavations here revealed various types of megalithic monuments such as umbrella stones, capstones, and rock-cut caves. The findings included iron implements, beads, and skeletal remains, indicating a well-developed Iron Age society. Babington's work is particularly important as it represents the first recorded scientific excavation of megaliths in Kerala.

Another major site is Porkalam (Thrissur), excavated in 1948 by B. K. Thapar. This was the first major excavation in Kerala after independence. The site revealed urn burials, stone circles, and associated grave goods such as pottery, iron tools, beads, and bone fragments. Based on comparative analysis with other South Indian sites, Porkalam has been dated between the 3rd century BCE and the 1st century CE, highlighting its importance in the broader context of South Indian megalithic culture. The Mangadu (Kollam) excavation, carried out in 1992 by T. Satyamurthy, uncovered several burial urns along with pottery, iron implements, and carnelian beads. The predominance of agricultural tools suggests that the people were primarily agrarian. Carbon dating indicates that this site dates back to around 1000–800 BCE, providing evidence for the early beginning of the Iron Age in Kerala.

Ummichipoyil (Kasaragod) is another important site known for its rock-cut cave burials. Excavations conducted by the Archaeological Survey of India revealed pottery, iron objects, and unique channel-spouted vessels. These findings suggest cultural continuity from the Neolithic to the Megalithic period and are dated between 500 BCE and 500 CE. Finally, Anakkara (Palakkad), excavated by Mahatma Gandhi University between 2008 and 2009, yielded a variety of burial types including stone circles, urn burials, and umbrella stones. The site also produced iron weapons, pottery, beads, and bone fragments. Significantly, evidence of Mesolithic tools was found beneath the megalithic layer, indicating a long sequence of human habitation. Together, these sites provide a comprehensive picture of Kerala's prehistoric and early historic cultural development.

J. Babington

John Babington, a British administrator and early antiquarian, holds a significant place in the history of Kerala archaeology as the first person to systematically notice and excavate megalithic monuments in the region. His work in 1819 at Chattaparamba, near present-day Feroke in Kozhikode district, marks the beginning of scientific archaeological inquiry into Kerala's prehistoric past. At a time when archaeology was still in its formative stage, Babington's observations and documentation were remarkably detailed and methodical. Interestingly, Babington did not use the modern term "megalith" to describe these burial monuments. Instead, he referred to them as "Pandoo Coolies," a term derived from local usage. This reflects how early scholars often relied on indigenous knowledge and terminology while interpreting ancient remains. His excavation at Chattaparamba revealed a cluster of burial monuments, including umbrella stones (kudakkallu), capstones (topikkallu), and rock-cut caves. These structures indicated complex burial practices and a well-developed cultural tradition among the ancient inhabitants.

In 1821, Babington published a detailed report titled "Description of Pandoo Coolies in Malabar" in the Transactions of the Literary Society of Bombay. This report is considered the first scholarly account of megalithic monuments in Kerala. It is notable not only for its descriptive content but also for its inclusion of illustrations, which helped visualize the structures and burial arrangements. Babington also recorded local myths and beliefs associated with these monuments, thereby combining archaeological observation with ethnographic insight. The excavation yielded several important artefacts that shed light on the material culture of the Iron Age society. These included iron implements such as tridents, tripods, and various tools, along with beads and skeletal remains. The presence of iron objects indicates the technological advancement of the people, while beads suggest possible trade connections and aesthetic sensibilities. The discovery of bones

confirms that these monuments were indeed burial sites, providing valuable evidence about funerary practices and beliefs in life after death. Overall, Babington's work laid the foundation for future archaeological studies in Kerala. His pioneering efforts helped bring attention to the richness of Kerala's megalithic heritage and opened new avenues for understanding the region's early history.

Significance of J. Babington's Work

The work of J. Babington occupies a foundational place in the study of Kerala's megalithic culture. His excavation at Chattaparamba in 1819 is widely regarded as the first scientific attempt to study megalithic monuments in the region. At a time when archaeology was not yet a fully developed discipline, Babington's approach demonstrated a level of observation and documentation that set an early standard for future research. One of the most important aspects of Babington's work is that it represents the first systematic and scientific study of megaliths in Kerala. Instead of merely describing the monuments as curiosities, he carefully examined their structure, location, and contents. This marked a shift from casual observation to analytical investigation, which is a key feature of modern archaeology. His effort laid the groundwork for later scholars to study these monuments more rigorously.

Another major contribution of Babington was his use of illustrations and detailed descriptions. In his 1821 publication, he included drawings of the burial monuments such as umbrella stones, capstones, and rock-cut caves. These visual representations were extremely valuable because photography was not widely available at that time. The illustrations helped scholars and readers better understand the form and construction of these structures, making his work both informative and accessible.

Babington also recorded local myths, traditions, and beliefs associated with these monuments. By doing so, he preserved valuable oral histories and cultural interpretations that might otherwise have been lost. His inclusion of the landscape and surroundings of the burial sites added another dimension to his study, showing how these monuments were connected to their natural environment. This combination of archaeological and ethnographic observation makes his work unique and comprehensive. Furthermore, Babington made an early attempt to classify different types of megalithic monuments and to describe excavation methods. Although his techniques were not as advanced as modern archaeological practices, they represented an important beginning. His efforts to distinguish between different burial forms and document their contents show an emerging awareness of typology and methodology.

B. K. Thapar – Porkalam Excavation (1948)

The excavation at Porkalam in Thrissur district, conducted in 1948 by B. K. Thapar, marks a turning point in the archaeological study of Kerala. It was the first major excavation carried out in the region after India gained independence, and therefore holds both historical and academic significance. Thapar, who later became the Director General of the Archaeological Survey of India, approached the site with a scientific and systematic methodology, reflecting the growing professionalism in Indian archaeology during the mid-twentieth century. At Porkalam, Thapar excavated different types of megalithic burial monuments, including urn burials and stone circles. These burial forms are characteristic of the South Indian megalithic tradition. The urn burial consisted of a large pyriform (pear-shaped) pot placed in a pit, which served as a container for the remains of the deceased. Surrounding burial structures such as stone circles indicated the marked presence of funerary rituals and memorial practices. Some of the burial structures were found to be disturbed or damaged, but the remaining intact urn burial provided valuable archaeological data.

The excavation yielded a rich collection of artefacts that shed light on the material culture of the people. These included pottery such as burial urns and associated vessels, iron implements, beads, and bone fragments. The discovery of iron tools indicates the use of advanced metal technology, while the beads—particularly semi-precious ones like carnelian—suggest aesthetic preferences as well as possible trade connections with other regions. The presence of bones confirms that these sites were used for burial purposes and provides insight into funerary customs. One of the most important contributions of Thapar's work was his comparative analysis. He compared the artefacts and burial types found at Porkalam with those from other megalithic sites in South India, particularly in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka. This comparative approach helped situate Porkalam within the broader framework of South Indian megalithic culture and demonstrated cultural similarities and interactions across regions. Based on this analysis, Thapar dated the Porkalam megaliths to a period ranging from the 3rd century BCE to the 1st century CE. This dating is crucial as it places the site within the early historic period, linking it to wider developments in South Indian history. Overall, the Porkalam excavation significantly enhanced our understanding of Kerala's megalithic past and its connections with the larger cultural landscape of peninsular India.

T. Satyamurthy – Mangadu Excavation (1992)

The excavation at Mangadu in Kollam district, carried out in 1992 by T. Satyamurthy of the Archaeological Survey of India, is one of the most important archaeological investigations for understanding the early Iron Age in Kerala. This excavation brought to light crucial evidence about burial practices, material culture, and the socio-economic life of the megalithic people in the region. During the excavation, about twelve burial urns were unearthed. These urns were large, handmade containers made of dull red ware and were generally found without lids. They were placed in pits and used for burial purposes, confirming the existence of urn burial practices in the region. Along with the large urns, associated burial pottery of different sizes was also discovered. The pottery assemblage mainly included Red ware, Black and Red ware, and other related ceramic types. The variation in pottery suggests a developed ceramic tradition and indicates the technological skills of the people.

In addition to pottery, a number of iron implements were recovered from the burial sites. These included tools such as knives, sickles, wedges, and blades. Interestingly, the absence of weapons like swords or spears is a notable feature of this site. This suggests that the people of Mangadu were not primarily warriors but were engaged in agricultural activities. The presence of tools like sickles and cutting instruments clearly indicates their involvement in farming and related occupations. Another important finding from Mangadu was the discovery of carnelian beads, some of which were etched. Carnelian is a semi-precious stone, and its presence indicates trade connections with other regions of India, particularly areas like Gujarat where such materials were commonly sourced. This shows that the people of Mangadu were not isolated but were part of wider trade networks.

The significance of the Mangadu excavation lies in its clear evidence of an agricultural society supported by iron technology. Based on Carbon-14 dating, the site has been dated to around 1000 BCE to 800 BCE. This is particularly important because it suggests that the Iron Age in Kerala began as early as 1000 BCE. Thus, the Mangadu excavation plays a key role in establishing the chronology of early Kerala history and highlights the transition to a more advanced and settled way of life.

Ummichipoyil Excavation (2001)

The Ummichipoyil excavation, carried out in 2001 by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), is an important milestone in the study of megalithic culture in northern Kerala. This site is located in Karinthalam village in Hosdurg Taluk of Kasaragod district, a region known for its laterite hill formations. The geographical setting of the site is significant, as many megalithic monuments in Kerala are found on elevated laterite plateaus, suggesting a deliberate selection of landscape for burial purposes. Ummichipoyil is particularly noted for its rock-cut cave burials, which are an important type of megalithic monument. These caves are carved into laterite rock and were used as burial chambers for the dead. Archaeologists identified around eleven such caves at the site, although only four were excavated in detail, as the others were found in a disturbed or damaged condition. The presence of multiple caves indicates that this area may have served as a significant burial ground for a community over a long period.

The excavation yielded a variety of artefacts that provide insights into the material culture of the people. Among the findings were different types of pottery, including Red ware, Black ware, and Black and Red ware. One of the most notable discoveries was the presence of channel-spouted vessels, which are characteristic of certain early cultural traditions. These vessels are important because they show stylistic and functional continuity from earlier periods. In addition to pottery, several iron objects were also recovered, indicating the use of iron technology during this period.
One of the key historical significances of the Ummichipoyil excavation is that it demonstrates continuity from the Neolithic to the Megalithic period. The discovery of pottery types resembling earlier Neolithic traditions suggests that cultural practices evolved gradually rather than appearing suddenly. This continuity helps historians understand the transition from stone-based tool cultures to iron-using societies in Kerala.

Based on the typology and style of the burial caves and associated artefacts, the Ummichipoyil site has been tentatively dated between 500 BCE and 500 CE. This wide time range indicates prolonged use of the site and highlights its importance in the study of long-term cultural development. Overall, the Ummichipoyil excavation provides valuable evidence for understanding burial practices, technological progress, and cultural continuity in ancient Kerala.

Anakkara Excavation (2008–09)

The Anakkara excavation, carried out during 2008–2009 by the School of Social Sciences, Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam, is one of the most significant archaeological investigations in Kerala in recent times. The excavation was led by noted historians and archaeologists including Rajan Gurukkal, along with V. Selvakumar and K. P. Shajan. Located in Palakkad district, Anakkara occupies a strategic position near the Palakkad Gap, which has historically served as an important corridor connecting Kerala with the Tamil plains. This geographical location adds further importance to the site in understanding cultural interactions.

The excavation revealed a variety of megalithic burial types, indicating a complex and well-developed funerary tradition. These included stone circles, urn burials, and umbrella stones (kudakkallu). Some burial structures also contained rock-cut cave chambers, suggesting diversity in burial practices. The presence of multiple burial forms in a single site indicates that the area was used by a community over a long period and possibly reflects variations in social or cultural practices. A wide range of burial goods was unearthed during the excavation. These included different types of pottery such as Black and Red Ware, Red Slipped Ware, and Black Burnished Ware. Iron objects formed a major part of the findings and included weapons like swords, daggers,

arrowheads, and tridents, as well as tools and lamps. The presence of such weapons suggests that warfare or martial activities may have been significant in this society. In addition, beads made of semi-precious stones like carnelian and materials like steatite were also discovered, indicating trade connections and aesthetic sensibilities. Bone fragments, including charred bones, were recovered from the urns, confirming burial practices.

One of the most remarkable features of the Anakkara excavation is the discovery of Mesolithic tools beneath the Iron Age layer. During a trial trench conducted near the megalithic structures, archaeologists unearthed about 24 quartz tools belonging to the Mesolithic period. This finding is highly significant because it provides clear evidence of an earlier phase of human habitation in the region. It shows that the area was occupied continuously from the Mesolithic (Stone Age) to the Iron Age, highlighting a long cultural sequence.
Thus, the Anakkara excavation not only enriches our understanding of megalithic culture but also bridges the gap between prehistoric and early historic periods in Kerala.

In short megalithic excavations in Kerala have provided a rich and reliable source of information for reconstructing the early history of the region. These archaeological findings are not merely remnants of burial sites, but valuable historical records that reveal multiple aspects of ancient life, including beliefs, technology, economy, and cultural development. One of the most important contributions of megalithic excavations is the understanding of burial practices and religious beliefs. The presence of different types of burial monuments such as urn burials, stone circles, dolmens, and umbrella stones indicates a well-developed funerary tradition. The inclusion of grave goods like pottery, iron tools, beads, and sometimes food items suggests a belief in life after death. People believed that the deceased would require these items in the next world. Variations in the quantity and quality of burial goods also indicate differences in social status, pointing towards the existence of social hierarchy in early Kerala society.

Megalithic sites also provide clear evidence of the use of iron technology and the importance of agriculture. The discovery of iron implements such as sickles, knives, plough-related tools, and occasionally weapons shows that people had mastered iron metallurgy. Agricultural tools, in particular, indicate that farming was a primary occupation. This reflects a settled lifestyle, where communities depended on cultivation rather than hunting and gathering alone. Another significant aspect revealed by these excavations is the existence of trade and external contacts. The discovery of semi-precious stone beads, especially carnelian, suggests connections with regions like Gujarat and other parts of India. These materials were not locally available, indicating that the people of Kerala were part of wider trade networks. This shows that early Kerala was not isolated but actively engaged in cultural and economic exchanges.

Perhaps one of the most important insights is the continuity from the Stone Age to the Iron Age. Excavations such as those at Anakkara have revealed Mesolithic tools beneath megalithic layers, proving that human habitation in the region dates back to earlier prehistoric periods. This continuity highlights the gradual evolution of culture and technology rather than sudden change.
In conclusion, megalithic excavations serve as a crucial source for understanding the early history of Kerala. They provide a comprehensive picture of ancient society, making them indispensable for historical reconstruction.

Megalithic Culture Economy and Society

The megalithic period, belonging to the Iron Age and overlapping with the Early Historic phase, is best understood through its burial monuments and grave goods. These monuments are not just archaeological remains; they are valuable sources that reveal the spiritual and cultural life of the people. The megalithic society had strong beliefs in life after death and ancestor worship. Their burial practices, such as urn burials, cists, and dolmens, clearly show that death was not considered the end of life. Instead, they believed that the soul continued to exist, and therefore, the dead were buried with objects like weapons, pottery, ornaments, and daily-use items. Early Tamil literary works such as Purananooru and Manimekalai also support these ideas by describing different types of burial practices in ancient Tamizhakam. Scholars like William Logan have interpreted these practices as part of a system of rituals meant to honor and appease the spirits of the dead.

Megalithic Culture in Ancient Kerala

The megalithic culture of ancient Kerala represents an important phase in the region's history, broadly corresponding to the Iron Age and extending into the Early Historic period. This culture is primarily identified through its distinctive burial practices, which provide valuable insights into the life, beliefs, and social organization of the people. The term "megalith" literally means "large stone," and it refers to the stone structures used in burial monuments such as dolmens, urn burials, and cists. These monuments were not merely graves but carefully constructed memorials, indicating a high degree of planning, skill, and cultural significance.

The key features of megalithic culture are best understood through these burial remains. Dolmens, which are stone table-like structures, and cists, which are stone-lined burial chambers, reflect advanced knowledge of stone construction. Urn burials, on the other hand, involved placing the remains of the dead in large pottery vessels. The diversity in these burial types suggests that the society was not uniform but stratified. Different forms of burials may have been used for individuals of varying social status, pointing to the existence of a hierarchical social structure.

The social organization of the megalithic people appears to have been well-developed. The variation in burial practices indicates that distinctions were made based on rank, wealth, or occupation. Some graves contain rich assemblages of goods, while others are relatively simple, further reinforcing the idea of inequality and social differentiation. This suggests that megalithic society was organized, with clearly defined roles and positions. Culturally, the megalithic people held strong beliefs regarding life after death. This is evident from the presence of grave goods such as pottery, beads, iron tools, and weapons placed alongside the deceased. These items were likely intended for use in the afterlife, reflecting a belief in the continuation of existence beyond death. Additionally, the inclusion of such objects points to ritual practices and symbolic expressions of identity.

Megalithic Economy – Subsistence

The subsistence pattern of the megalithic people in ancient Kerala was diverse and well-developed, reflecting a mixed economy that combined several means of livelihood. Rather than relying on a single economic activity, the megalithic communities practiced hunting and gathering, animal husbandry, and agriculture simultaneously. This combination ensured stability and adaptability to different environmental conditions. Hunting and gathering continued to play an important role, especially in forested regions. The presence of iron weapons such as spearheads, arrowheads, and knives in burial sites suggests that hunting was a common activity. These tools

were used not only for securing food but also for protection and possibly for warfare. Alongside hunting, animal husbandry formed another essential component of the economy. The domestication of animals such as cattle, sheep, and goats provided meat, milk, and other resources, and these animals may also have been used for agricultural purposes like ploughing.

Agriculture, however, emerged as the most significant aspect of the megalithic economy. The introduction and widespread use of iron technology brought major changes in farming practices. Iron tools such as axes were used to clear forests and reclaim land for cultivation, enabling the expansion of agricultural activities. Other tools like knives and sickles improved efficiency in harvesting and processing crops. The use of iron thus marked a shift towards more productive and organized agriculture. One of the key developments during this period was the beginning of multi-crop farming. This indicates that the megalithic people cultivated a variety of crops rather than depending on a single type, which helped in ensuring food security and reducing risks associated with crop failure. Such diversification reflects a growing understanding of agricultural practices and environmental management.

Archaeological evidence further supports the existence of advanced agriculture. The discovery of iron ploughshares from sites in Wayanad and Kollam clearly indicates the practice of plough-based cultivation. This represents a significant technological advancement, as ploughing increases soil fertility and crop yield. It also suggests that agriculture was not merely subsistence-based but had the potential for surplus production. In short, the megalithic economy of Kerala was dynamic and multifaceted. It was based on a balanced combination of hunting, pastoralism, and agriculture, with iron technology playing a crucial role in its development. This diverse, iron-based economy laid the foundation for the growth of settled agricultural communities and the later economic progress of the region.

Trade & Craft Production in the Megalithic Economy

Trade and craft production formed a vital component of the megalithic economy in ancient Kerala, indicating a society that was not only self-sufficient but also actively connected with distant ancient cultures. The megalithic culture of ancient Kerala reflects a well-structured and belief-oriented society. It demonstrates not only technological advancement and social organization but also a deep cultural and spiritual outlook that shaped their burial traditions and way of life. One of the most significant pieces of evidence for trade comes from the discovery of semi-precious stone beads in megalithic burial sites. Stones such as carnelian, quartz, beryl, and amethyst have been found in considerable quantities. These materials are not naturally available in Kerala, which clearly suggests that they were brought from other regions, particularly from areas like present-day Maharashtra and Gujarat. This indicates the existence of long-distance trade networks and the movement of goods across regions.

The presence of these beads also points to the role of merchants and artisans in the megalithic economy. Either the raw materials were imported and locally crafted into ornaments, or finished products were traded into Kerala. In both cases, it reflects an organized system of exchange and interaction with other parts of the Indian subcontinent. Such exchanges were not limited to stones alone. The discovery of metals such as copper, bronze, and gold further strengthens the argument for active trade. These metals, often used for making ornaments and tools, indicate both wealth and technological awareness.

Craft production was another important feature of the megalithic economy. Iron working, in particular, was highly developed. Archaeological findings, including iron implements and smelting remains like crucibles, suggest that the megalithic people possessed knowledge of iron extraction,

smelting, and tool-making. This technological advancement supported various economic activities, especially agriculture and hunting.

Pottery making was equally significant. The megalithic people produced a variety of pottery types, including the well-known Black and Red Ware, which is often associated with this period. Other types such as Red Slipped Ware and painted pottery also highlight their craftsmanship. These pottery items were made using the potter's wheel and fired in kilns, indicating a high level of skill and technological sophistication. Some large burial urns were handmade, showing both functional and ritual uses of pottery. Thus, the megalithic economy of Kerala was marked by active trade and advanced craft production. The evidence of long-distance exchange, combined with skilled craftsmanship in iron working and pottery, reflects a dynamic and interconnected society with strong economic foundations.

Technology & Historical Views on Megalithic Economy

The megalithic culture of ancient Kerala demonstrates a notable level of technological advancement, particularly in the fields of construction and craft production. One of the most striking features of this period is the construction of large stone monuments such as dolmens and cists. These structures, built using massive stone slabs, required not only physical effort but also technical knowledge in quarrying, transporting, and assembling stones. The precision and durability of these monuments indicate that the megalithic people possessed considerable expertise in stone masonry. In addition to dolmens and cists, other structures such as rock-cut chambers and stone circles further highlight their architectural skills and planning abilities.

Pottery was another area where technological sophistication is clearly visible. The megalithic people produced a variety of pottery types using the potter's wheel, which marks an important technological development. The use of kilns for firing pottery ensured durability and improved quality. Well-known pottery types such as Black and Red Ware, along with other varieties, reflect both functional and aesthetic aspects of their craftsmanship. Some large burial urns were handmade, indicating a combination of simple and advanced techniques. These pottery items were not only used in daily life but also played an important role in burial practices.

Historians and archaeologists have offered different interpretations regarding the nature of the megalithic economy and society. A. Sreedhara Menon viewed the megalithic people as settled agriculturists who depended primarily on farming for their livelihood. His interpretation is supported by the discovery of agricultural tools and evidence of land cultivation. On the other hand, Rajan Gurukkal emphasized the idea of a mixed economy. According to him, the megalithic society combined agriculture with other activities such as hunting, animal husbandry, and craft production, making their economy more diverse and adaptable.

Both views contribute to a broader understanding of the megalithic period. While agriculture likely formed the economic base, the presence of various other activities suggests a complex and well-developed system. The differences observed in burial monuments and grave goods also point to the existence of social hierarchy, where individuals were distinguished by status and wealth. In short, the megalithic period in Kerala was marked by advanced technology and a dynamic economic structure. It was primarily agriculture-based but supported by multiple activities, and it reflected a socially stratified and culturally rich society.

Burial Practices of Early Tamizhakam

The burial practices of Early Tamizhakam provide deep insights into the social life, beliefs, and cultural diversity of ancient South Indian society. Much of our understanding of these practices comes from early Tamil literary sources, especially the Sangam corpus. One of the important works, Purananooru, refers to two major forms of disposal of the dead: Iduka (exposed burial) and Chuduka (cremation). These references indicate that multiple methods of treating the dead coexisted, reflecting a society with varied customs and beliefs. Another significant source is the Tamil epic Manimekalai, which gives a more elaborate description of burial practices. It refers to several methods followed by the people, especially in urban centers like Puhar (Kaveripattinam). Among these, cremation (Suduvor) was a common practice in which the body was burnt, possibly accompanied by rituals. Exposure (Iduvor) involved leaving the body in the open, perhaps for natural decomposition, which might be linked to specific cultural or ecological beliefs.

Pit burial (Thodukuzhi) was another important method, where the body or remains were placed in pits dug into the ground. In some cases, these pits were lined with stones, resembling the sub-terrain cist burials seen in megalithic traditions. Urn burial (Thaazhvayinadai) involved placing the remains inside a large burial urn and covering it, often with an inverted lid. A related practice, Thaazhiyil kavippor, refers to the careful placement of remains within urns for funerary purposes, indicating ritual significance and respect for the dead. The variety of these burial practices clearly shows that Early Tamizhakam was not culturally uniform. Instead, it was marked by diversity in funeral customs, which may have depended on factors such as social status, community traditions, or regional differences. These practices also suggest a strong belief in life after death, as the methods of burial often involved care, ritual, and symbolism.

Society of Megalithic People

The society of the megalithic people in ancient Kerala was complex, organized, and marked by a high degree of specialization. Archaeological evidence, especially from burial monuments and grave goods, reveals the presence of various skilled occupational groups. These included stone masons, potters, ironsmiths, goldsmiths, and bead makers. Each of these groups contributed significantly to the functioning of society, indicating a division of labour and the emergence of professional specialization. Stone masons played a crucial role in constructing megalithic monuments such as dolmens, cists, and stone circles. These structures required technical knowledge in selecting, shaping, and placing large stones, reflecting considerable architectural skill. Potters were equally important, producing a wide range of pottery types, including Black and Red Ware, which were used in both daily life and burial practices. The use of the potter’s wheel and kiln suggests technological advancement and efficiency in production.

Ironsmiths occupied a central place in megalithic society, as iron was the most important metal of the period. The discovery of numerous iron implements such as axes, knives, swords, and agricultural tools indicates that iron working was highly developed. Iron smelting was a specialized craft that required knowledge of extracting metal from ore and shaping it into useful tools. This technological advancement greatly influenced agriculture, hunting, and warfare, thereby strengthening the economic base of society.

Goldsmiths and bead makers also contributed to the cultural and economic life of the people. The presence of ornaments made of gold and semi-precious stones like carnelian and beryl indicates not only craftsmanship but also trade connections with distant regions. These artisans produced decorative items that may have symbolized wealth and social status. The economic life of the megalithic people was equally diverse. They engaged in hunting, fishing, and cultivation, making use of the natural resources available in their environment. Agriculture appears to have been a major

activity, supported by iron tools that improved productivity. In addition, both internal and external trade played a significant role, as evidenced by the presence of non-local materials in burial sites. In general, the megalithic society of ancient Kerala was highly skilled and well-organized. The existence of specialized occupational groups, advanced iron technology, and a diversified economy highlights the complexity and dynamism of their social structure.

Survival of Megalithic Traditions (Kerala Tribes)

The survival of megalithic traditions among the tribal communities of Kerala provides an important link between the ancient past and the living present. One of the earliest scholars to systematically study this continuity was L. A. Krishna Iyer, a pioneering social anthropologist of Kerala. Through his ethnographic surveys, he examined the customs and practices of several tribal groups, including the Kurichiyar, Paniyar, and Kadar, and identified striking similarities between their burial traditions and those of the ancient megalithic culture. Krishna Iyer observed that certain elements of megalithic burial practices have continued, though in modified forms, among these communities. One of the most notable features is the construction of miniature dolmens. While ancient megalithic dolmens were large and elaborate stone structures used as burial monuments, the tribal communities often build smaller versions of these structures as memorials, especially in cases of unnatural death. This suggests not only a continuity of tradition but also an adaptation of ancient practices to present-day conditions.

Another important observation is the use of stone markers in burial practices. Some tribal groups place stones at specific points of the grave, such as the head, feet, or chest of the deceased. In certain cases, stones are arranged in circular patterns around the burial site, forming stone circles. These practices closely resemble the megalithic tradition of marking graves with large stones or arranging them in specific patterns, indicating a symbolic connection with ancestral customs. These burial practices are not merely physical acts but are deeply connected with beliefs about death and the afterlife. The continued use of stone structures and markers reflects a cultural memory that has been preserved over generations. It also suggests that the tribes maintain a spiritual relationship with their ancestors, similar to the beliefs held by the megalithic people.

The observations of L. A. Krishna Iyer highlight the continuity of megalithic traditions among thethem tribal communities of Kerala. Despite changes over time, essential elements such as dolmen-like structures and stone markers have survived, demonstrating the enduring nature of these ancient cultural practices and their relevance in understanding the region’s historical heritage.

Ethnoarchaeological Views

Ethnoarchaeology helps us understand ancient cultures by studying the practices of living communities and comparing with archaeological evidence. In the context of Kerala, scholars have used this approach to trace the survival of megalithic traditions among present-day tribal groups. Two important contributors in this field are Ajit Kumar and Manjula Povil, whose studies provide valuable insights into continuity in burial customs and beliefs. Ajit Kumar conducted a detailed study on the Cholanaikans, a tribal community living in the Nilambur region of Kerala. His observations reveal striking similarities between their burial practices and those of the ancient megalithic people. The Cholanaikans practise primary extended burial, where the body is laid out in a pit along with the personal belongings of the deceased. The nature of these grave goods varies according to age and gender. For a deceased man, tools such as an iron axe, knife, and other objects related to his daily life are placed in the grave. For women, vessels, food items, and domestic objects are included, sometimes even accompanied by a hearth prepared beside the body,

symbolizing their role in cooking even in the afterlife. In the case of children, items such as toys, milk, and clothing are placed in the burial pit. These practices clearly indicate a strong belief in life after death and the continuation of worldly roles beyond death. Ajit Kumar interprets this as evidence of belief in the soul and its rebirth.

Similarly, Manjula Povil studied the mortuary practices of tribal populations in northern Kerala and found significant parallels with megalithic traditions. She observed the continued use of commemorative stones in burial sites, a practice that directly reflects the megalithic custom of marking graves with stones. These stones serve not only as memorials but also as symbols of remembrance and ancestral connection. Together, these studies highlight the persistence of ancient cultural patterns in modern tribal societies. The inclusion of grave goods, the use of stone markers, and the belief in afterlife all point to a deep-rooted cultural continuity. In conclusion, ethnoarchaeological evidence strongly supports the idea that megalithic traditions have not disappeared but have survived in transformed ways among the tribal communities of Kerala, reflecting enduring beliefs and cultural heritage.

Megalithic Beliefs (Kerala)

The megalithic culture of ancient Kerala reveals a rich system of beliefs centered on death, the afterlife, and the relationship between the living and the dead. One of the most significant aspects of these beliefs is the strong conviction in life after death. The megalithic people did not consider death as the end of existence; instead, they believed that the soul continued to live in another form. This belief is clearly reflected in their burial practices, where various goods such as pottery, iron tools, ornaments, and food items were placed along with the dead. These objects were probably intended for use in the afterlife, indicating a continuation of worldly life beyond death. Another important feature of megalithic belief was ancestor worship. The dead were not forgotten but were respected, remembered, and possibly feared. It was believed that the spirits of the ancestors possessed supernatural powers and could influence the lives of the living. Therefore, rituals and offerings were made to honor them and to seek their protection or avoid their displeasure. This shows a close spiritual connection between the living community and their ancestors.

In Kerala, archaeological evidence suggests that secondary burials were more common. In this practice, the remains of the deceased were collected after the initial decomposition and then reburied in urns or stone structures. This indicates a complex and ritualized approach to death, involving multiple stages of burial. Various types of burial monuments have been found, including urn burials, cists, dolmens, and stone circles. Each of these reflects not only different methods of disposal of the dead but also variations in ritual practices and possibly social status.

Literary sources from ancient Tamilakam, such as Purananooru and Manimekalai, also refer to different burial practices, supporting the archaeological findings. These texts highlight the diversity of funeral customs and the importance given to death rituals in early South Indian society.
In conclusion, the megalithic beliefs of Kerala were deeply spiritual and complex. The emphasis on life after death, ancestor worship, and elaborate burial practices clearly shows that burials were not merely a means of disposal but a reflection of profound religious and cultural values.

Rituals & Ideas in Megalithic Kerala

The ritual practices and belief systems of the megalithic people in Kerala reflect a deeply spiritual outlook centered on death and the afterlife. One of the earliest scholars to interpret these practices was William Logan, who closely studied the burial monuments and associated grave goods. According to him, the megalithic people believed that the dead continued to exist as spirits

after death and had the power to influence the lives of the living. This belief led to the practice of offering various objects to the deceased in order to please or propitiate them.

The burial sites often contained a variety of items such as weapons, pottery, ornaments, lamps, water jars, and other daily-use objects. These items were not placed randomly; rather, they were carefully selected based on what the deceased had used or valued during their lifetime. Weapons like swords and spears suggest that the individual may have been a warrior, while pots and vessels indicate domestic life. Ornaments and decorative items reflect wealth, status, and personal identity. Lamps and oil containers may have symbolized light and continuity in the afterlife. Such offerings clearly indicate that the megalithic people believed the deceased would continue to need these objects in another world.

The idea that the dead possessed supernatural powers was central to megalithic belief. The spirits of the ancestors were both respected and feared. It was thought that if they were not properly honored, they could bring misfortune to the living. Therefore, rituals and offerings were essential to maintain harmony between the living and the dead. This belief system gave rise to the practice of treating burial monuments with great reverence. Megalithic monuments themselves were often regarded as the “pagodas of the dead.” This expression highlights their sacred nature, as these structures were not merely graves but also places of ritual and remembrance. They functioned as symbolic centers where the living could connect with their ancestors and express their respect.

In short the megalithic culture of ancient Kerala represents a crucial stage in the region’s historical development, marking the transition from the Iron Age to the Early Historic period. The term “megalith” refers to large stone burial monuments, which are among the most visible and significant archaeological remains of this period. These monuments, including dolmens, cists, urn burials, and stone circles, provide valuable insights into the beliefs, social structure, and economic life of the people.

One of the most striking features of megalithic culture is the strong belief in life after death. This is clearly reflected in the elaborate burial practices and the inclusion of grave goods such as pottery, iron tools, weapons, ornaments, and food items. These objects were likely placed in the graves with the intention that they would be used by the deceased in the afterlife. Such practices indicate not only ritual significance but also a deep spiritual outlook and concern for the life beyond death. The variety and richness of burial monuments and grave goods also point to the existence of social hierarchy within megalithic society. Some burials are simple, while others are elaborate and contain a large number of valuable items. This variation suggests differences in status, wealth, and possibly occupation among individuals. Thus, megalithic society was not uniform but stratified, with clear distinctions between different social groups.

Technological advancement is another important aspect of this period. The widespread use of iron tools and weapons indicates a high level of metallurgical knowledge. Iron technology played a key role in improving agricultural productivity, clearing forests, and supporting other economic activities. In addition to iron working, the megalithic people also excelled in pottery making, producing various types of ceramics using the wheel and kiln. These crafts demonstrate both skill and innovation. The economy of the megalithic period was diverse and well-developed. Agriculture formed its backbone, with evidence of multi-crop farming and the use of iron ploughs. Alongside agriculture, pastoral activities, hunting, and trade contributed to economic stability. The presence of non-local materials in burial sites suggests active trade networks and exchange relations.

In short, the megalithic culture of Kerala presents a clear picture of a society deeply rooted in spiritual beliefs and ritual practices. The burial monuments and grave goods show that the people had a strong belief in life after death and maintained a close connection with their ancestors through various rituals. The practice of placing weapons, pottery, ornaments, and other objects in graves indicates that they believed the dead would continue their existence in another world. The idea that the spirits of the ancestors possessed supernatural powers further strengthened the need to respect and propitiate them.

Sample Question Paper

I Semester BA (CUFYUGP) Degree Examination

HIS1CJ101 History of Keralam upto 12th CE

Maximum Time: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 80**

Section A

Answer any 10 questions. Each carries 3 marks

(Ceiling 24 Marks)

1. Define grave goods and explain their importance in archaeology.
2. What are the four major categories of grave goods found in Kerala megaliths?
3. What is Black and Red Ware (BRW)? Why is it important?
4. Write a short note on Russet Coated Painted Ware (RCPW).
5. Mention any three iron objects discovered from megalithic burials in Kerala.
6. Explain the significance of beads in megalithic burials.
7. Distinguish between primary burial and secondary burial.
8. Why are bone fragments more common than complete skeletons in Kerala megaliths?
9. What are the major preservation issues affecting megalithic artefacts in Kerala?
10. Who was J. Babington? Mention his contribution to Kerala archaeology.
11. Write a short note on the Porkalam excavation.
12. Define the term Megalith.
13. What are grave goods? Mention any two examples found in megalithic burials.
14. Distinguish between primary burial and secondary burial.
15. What is Kodakkal? Mention its main structural features.
16. Write a short note on Thoppikkal.
17. What are rock-cut chambers? Name any two important sites in Kerala.
18. Explain the significance of stone circles (Kalvalayam) in megalithic culture.
19. What is a cist burial? Mention the importance of the porthole.
20. Differentiate between dolmens and cists.
21. What are menhirs? Why were they erected?
22. Write a short note on urn burials in Kerala.
23. What is a sarcophagus? Mention any two sites where sarcophagi have been found in Kerala.
24. Explain the importance of laterite in Kerala megalithic architecture.
25. Who was J. Babington? Explain his contribution to the study of megaliths in India.
26. Mention the major materials used in the construction of megaliths and give examples.
27. Define megalithic culture.
28. What are dolmens and cists?
29. What is meant by urn burial?
30. Mention any three grave goods found in megalithic burials.
31. What is Black and Red Ware?
32. Explain the term “secondary burial.”
33. What are the main features of the megalithic economy?
34. What evidence suggests the existence of trade in megalithic Kerala?

35. Who was L. A. Krishna Iyer and what was his contribution to the study of megalithic traditions?
36. What is ancestor worship in the context of megalithic culture?
37. Mention any two burial practices referred to in *Purananuru*.
38. What is meant by ethnoarchaeology?
39. Name any three occupational groups in megalithic society.
40. What is the importance of iron technology in megalithic Kerala?

Section B

Answer 8 Questions. Each carries 5 marks

(Ceiling 36 Marks)

1. Discuss the importance of grave goods in reconstructing the early history of Kerala.
2. Explain the different types of pottery found in megalithic burials in Kerala.
3. Describe the features and significance of Black and Red Ware pottery.
4. Examine the importance of iron objects in understanding megalithic society.
5. Explain the role of beads as archaeological evidence for trade and ornamentation.
6. Discuss the importance of bone remains in the study of megalithic burial practices.
7. Examine the major preservation problems faced by megalithic sites in Kerala.
8. Discuss the contribution of J. Babington to the study of megaliths in Kerala.
9. Explain the significance of the Porkalam excavation conducted by B. K. Thapar.
10. Examine the relevance of the Anakkara excavation in tracing cultural continuity in Kerala.
11. Explain the importance of megaliths as archaeological sources for reconstructing the early history of Kerala.
12. Discuss the typological classification of megaliths in Kerala based on materials used.
13. Describe the structure, distribution, and significance of Kodakkal monuments.
14. Examine the burial practices associated with Thoppikkal monuments.
15. Explain the architectural features of rock-cut chambers in Kerala.
16. Discuss the distribution and significance of stone circles in Kerala.
17. Describe the structural features and archaeological importance of cist burials.
18. Examine the role of dolmens in understanding megalithic burial customs.
19. Discuss the commemorative and cultural significance of menhirs.
20. Explain the features and significance of urn burials in Kerala.
21. Discuss the characteristics and regional distribution of sarcophagus burials.
22. Examine the role of grave goods in understanding megalithic society.
23. Explain the important features of megalithic culture in ancient Kerala.
24. Discuss the role of grave goods in understanding megalithic beliefs.
25. Explain the subsistence pattern of the megalithic economy.
26. Analyse the importance of iron technology in megalithic society.
27. Describe the role of trade and craft production in the megalithic economy.
28. Explain the different burial practices mentioned in *Manimekalai*.
29. Discuss the technological achievements of the megalithic people.

30.Explain the social organization of megalithic society.
31.Discuss the significance of beads and ornaments in megalithic culture.
32.Explain the continuity of megalithic traditions among Kerala tribes.
33.Analyse the ethnoarchaeological observations of Ajit Kumar.
34.Explain the importance of ancestor worship in megalithic Kerala.

Section C

Answer any one question

(1x10=10)

1. Discuss in detail the significance of grave goods in understanding the cultural, technological, and social life of megalithic Kerala.
2. Analyse the different categories of grave goods found in Kerala megaliths with suitable examples.
3. Evaluate the contribution of major megalithic excavations in Kerala to the reconstruction of early history.
4. Critically examine the role of pottery and iron objects in understanding the Iron Age culture of Kerala.
5. Discuss in detail the typology of megaliths in Kerala and explain their archaeological significance.
6. Critically examine the burial practices of the megalithic people of Kerala with special reference to primary and secondary burials.
7. Analyse the different types of megalithic monuments in Kerala and explain what they reveal about the social and technological development of Iron Age society.
8. Describe the major megalithic monuments of Kerala such as Kodakkal, Thoppikkal, Cists, Dolmens, Menhirs, and Urn burials.
9. Evaluate the importance of megaliths as sources for understanding the cultural history of Kerala during the Iron Age and Early Historic period.
10. Discuss the economic life of the megalithic people of Kerala with special reference to agriculture, trade, and craft production.
11. Analyse the burial practices and belief systems of megalithic Kerala using archaeological and literary evidence.
12. Examine the social organization and technological advancement of megalithic society in ancient Kerala.
13. Discuss the survival of megalithic traditions among tribal communities of Kerala and explain the importance of ethnoarchaeological studies.